

Iran

Islamic spiritual leaders have governed the ancient country of Iran since 1979, making it one of the only two theocracies in the world.

Carpets

Iran is famous for its closely woven, intricately designed carpets and rugs that take many months to complete.

PERSIA—
ANCIENT IRAN—
WAS FAMOUS FOR
ITS MINIATURE
PAINTINGS.

Architecture

Many old Iranian mosques are decorated in brightly colored tiles, with gold domes and tall minarets from which the faithful are called to prayer.

Iraq

Lying across the fertile Tigris and Euphrates river valleys, Iraq is dominated by scorching desert in the south and west of the country, and mountains in its north and east.

Kuwait

Kuwait's oil reserves, which are the fifth largest in the world, have fueled the country's prosperity.

Bahrain

The tiny island nation of Bahrain was once a major producer of pearls, although oil and gas have transformed the local economy.

Qatar

The flat, dry, desert peninsula of Qatar relies on its abundance of oil and gas, since oil production and refining form the basis of its economy.

United Arab Emirates

In 1971 seven separate emirates came together to form a single, federated country: the UAE. One of the emirates—Dubai—has built extraordinary fan-shaped developments in the sea to attract foreign tourists.

Oman

The seas off Oman teem with fish, including tuna, anchovies, sardines, and cuttlefish, and are now being exploited by local fishermen.

The Gulf States

The south and west shores of the Gulf are occupied by a number of small Arab emirates, or kingdoms. All are awash in oil and gas and are using the money to develop other industries as well as tourism.

Yemen

It is thought that drinking coffee originated in Yemen, which still produces some of the world's finest coffee beans today.

Saudi Arabia

Oil has made Saudi Arabia fabulously rich, enabling it to develop new industries and build desalination plants—for turning seawater into useable freshwater.

Arabia

The Arabian peninsula mainly consists of a hot, dry desert that sits on top of the world's largest reserves of oil and natural gas, which have brought immense wealth to the region.

Israel

Israel was founded in 1948 as a homeland for Jews from around the world, but it is also home to many Palestinian Muslims and Christians.

Palestine

The River Jordan is the lowest river in the world. On its west bank, as well as in the Gaza Strip, Palestinians enjoy a limited home rule.

Jordan

The salt of the Dead Sea is collected and used in cooking and preserving food, while some people find the waters have healing properties.

Central Asia

The five "stans" or "lands" of Central Asia all became independent in 1991 after years of Russian rule. While Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan are largely flat and desertlike, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan are mountainous, and Kazakhstan consists of rolling steppes.